

GRADE 7 • ELA • STANDARD RL.7.4

Words, Tone & Sound

How writers choose words — and how those choices shape meaning, mood, and music in a text.

Definitions • 8 Task Cards • Passage



What you'll be able to do

01

Determine meaning

Figure out words and phrases from how they're used in the text.

02

Explain word choice

Say what a word's connotation adds beyond its dictionary meaning.

03

Analyze tone

Describe the author's attitude and prove it with word evidence.

04

Hear the sound

Explain how rhyme, repetition, and alliteration shape a section.

RL.7.4 in the students' own words

The official wording

“Determine the meaning of words and phrases as they are used in a text, including figurative and connotative meanings; analyze the impact of rhymes and other repetitions of sounds on a specific verse or stanza of a poem or section of a story or drama.”

What it really asks

Use the text to figure out tricky words.

Notice when a word means more than its definition.

Name the author's attitude — the tone.

Explain what repeated sounds do to a passage.

Literal vs. figurative meaning

Literal

The plain, dictionary meaning. The words mean exactly what they say.

EXAMPLE

“The runner was fast.”

Figurative

Language that means something other than the literal words — simile, metaphor, personification, hyperbole, idiom.

EXAMPLE

“The runner was a bolt of lightning.”

Denotation vs. connotation

Denotation is what a word means. Connotation is what a word makes you feel.

thrifty	careful with money	smart, responsible	Positive
frugal	careful with money	plain, practical	Neutral
stingy	careful with money	selfish, unwilling to share	Negative

Ask yourself: Why did the author pick this word instead of its synonym? The answer is almost always the tone.

Tone — the author's attitude

Tone

The attitude an author takes toward the subject or topic, revealed through word choice, perspective, and detail.

Mood

The feeling the reader gets from the text. Tone belongs to the writer; mood belongs to you.

A TONE WORD BANK

hopeful

bitter

playful

urgent

wistful

sarcastic

solemn

admiring

uneasy

matter-of-fact

Rhyme, repetition, and sound devices

Rhyme	Matching end sounds in words	night / light / bright
Alliteration	Same beginning consonant sound repeated	the wild wind whipped
Assonance	Same vowel sound repeated inside words	the lone road home
Consonance	Repeated consonant sounds inside or at the end	blank and think
Repetition	A word, phrase, or line used again on purpose	“Still the bell. Still the bell.”
Onomatopoeia	A word that imitates the sound it names	crackle, hiss, thud

RL.7.4 doesn't stop at naming the device — you must explain its effect on the verse, stanza, or section.

Context clues — four kinds to hunt for

Definition clue

The meaning is stated right there.

“The brooding sky, dark and heavy with threat, hung low.”

Synonym clue

A nearby word means the same thing.

“She was reluctant — unwilling, really — to begin.”

Antonym clue

A contrast word signals the opposite.

“Unlike his boisterous brother, Marcus was subdued.”

Inference clue

You piece it together from the situation.

“He trudged the last mile, pack biting his shoulders.”

Words you need to talk about words

text

Anything students can read, view, listen to, or explore — including poems, photographs, films, articles, music, and art.

phrase

A small group of words standing together as a unit, but without both a subject and a verb.

analyze

To examine the parts of something in order to understand the whole and how it works.

tone

The attitude an author takes toward a subject, revealed through word choice and perspective.

stanza

A grouped set of lines in a poem, set off by a space — like a paragraph in prose.

EXAMPLE PICTURE

One scene, two tones

The subject never changed. The words did.

VERSION A

“The little house rested on the hill, warm light spilling from its windows.”

Tone: peaceful, welcoming

VERSION B

“The house crouched on the bare hill, a thin light leaking from its windows.”

Tone: uneasy, watchful



WORKED EXAMPLE

One action, five word choices

Every synonym drags a different feeling behind it. That feeling is what RL.7.4 asks you to name.

She strolled

out of the room.

relaxed,
unhurried

She wandered

out of the room.

aimless, unsure

She walked

out of the room.

neutral, no
signal

She marched

out of the room.

determined, angry

She stomped

out of the room.

furious, childish

Sentence stem: The author chose _____ instead of _____, which makes the character seem _____.

STRATEGY

The four-step word attack

1

Stop & mark

Circle the unfamiliar word. Don't skip it.

2

Read around

Read the sentence before and after for clues.

3

Predict

Substitute a word you know. Does it still make sense?

4

Check & prove

Confirm with a dictionary, then quote the clue.

Step 4 is the one students skip — and it's the one that earns the points.

WORKED EXAMPLE

What repeated sound actually does

Listen to this stanza

The wind walked wide across the wheat,
and what it wanted, it would keep.

The wheat bent low. The wheat bent low.
And no one watching went to sleep.

— from “Harvest Watch” (original student text)

Alliteration

wind / walked / wide / wheat / wanted — the repeated w imitates the sound of moving air.

Repetition

“The wheat bent low” twice makes the bending feel relentless, not accidental.

Rhyme

keep / sleep ties the last line back to the wind's will — the reader can't escape it either.

SHARED READING

“The Long Way Home”

Before you read

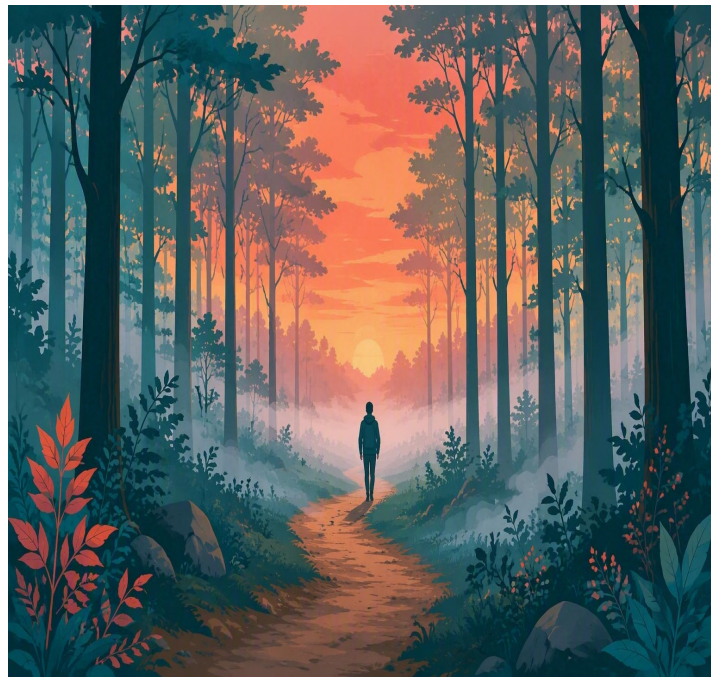
Set-up: Nadia misses the late bus and walks home through Kessler Wood for the first time.

Read once straight through for the story.

Read again with a pencil: circle unfamiliar words, underline mood words.

Be ready to name the tone — and prove it with three words.

Watch for: brooding · skirted · relented · din



The Long Way Home

The bus pulled away without her, and Nadia stood in the empty loop watching its taillights shrink to nothing. Thirty-five minutes on foot, or two hours waiting. She shouldered her pack and took the trail into Kessler Wood.

The sky had turned brooding — low, gray, and heavy with a threat it never quite delivered. Under the trees the light went soft and strange. She skirted a puddle that had swallowed half the path, then another, then gave up and walked straight through the third.

Somewhere behind her a branch cracked. Nadia did not turn around. She counted her steps instead — twenty, forty, sixty — and the counting steadied her the way her grandmother's humming used to.

The Long Way Home

By the time she reached the ridge, the rain had relented and the woods had gone quiet — no wind, no birds, only the small din of water dripping leaf to leaf to leaf.

From up here she could see her street: the crooked mailbox, the porch light her mother always left burning, the yellow square of the kitchen window. The house did not crouch. It waited.

Nadia let out a breath she hadn't known she was holding and started down. The long way home, it turned out, was still the way home.

“The house did not crouch. It waited.” — the tone turns here. Mark it.

How I'd annotate paragraph 2

“brooding”

Definition clue right after the dash: low, gray, heavy. I don't need a dictionary.

“skirted”

She avoided the puddle, then walked through one — so skirted must mean went around.

“soft and strange”

Two mood words together. The author wants unease, not fear — nothing bad has happened.

“never quite delivered”

The threat isn't real. The author is telling me the danger is in Nadia's head.

Notice: every note names the clue, not just the meaning.

STATION ROTATION

8 Task Cards

Work through the cards with your partner. Every answer needs a quote from the passage.

6–8 minutes per card

1

TASK CARD 1 · CONTEXT CLUES

7 min

Word Detective

Define four words using only the passage — no dictionary until you've predicted.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Write your predicted meaning for brooding, skirted, relented, and din.
- 2 Name which clue type helped you: definition, synonym, antonym, or inference.
- 3 Check one word in a dictionary. How close were you?

Prove it: I think _____ means _____ because the text says “_____.”

Shades of Meaning

Rank synonyms from gentlest to harshest and defend your order.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Rank: glanced · stared · glared · peeked · watched.
- 2 Mark each one positive, neutral, or negative.
- 3 Which one would fit Nadia in paragraph 3? Why that one?

Prove it: _____ feels harsher than _____ because it suggests _____.

Name It & Explain It

Find three figurative phrases in the passage and explain what each one really means.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Copy the phrase exactly, with quotation marks.
- 2 Label it: simile, metaphor, personification, or hyperbole.
- 3 Explain what it means literally — and why the figurative version is better.

Prove it: The author writes “_____,” which is _____ because _____.

4

TASK CARD 4 • PRECISION

6 min

Word Swap Lab

Replace one word in the passage and measure the damage.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Choose any vivid word and swap in a plain synonym.
- 2 Rewrite the full sentence both ways.
- 3 Explain exactly what the passage loses in your version.

Prove it: Changing _____ to _____ makes the sentence feel _____ instead of _____.

Prove the Tone

Name the tone of Part 1 in one precise word — then prove it three times.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Choose a tone word from the bank. No 'sad' or 'good.'
- 2 Pull three quotes that support it.
- 3 Explain how each quote creates that attitude.

Prove it: The tone of Part 1 is _____. The words “_____,” “_____,” and “_____” show it.

Find the Turn

Locate the exact sentence where the tone changes — and explain the switch.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Mark the sentence where the mood lifts.
- 2 Name the tone before and the tone after.
- 3 List the word choices that signal the shift.

Prove it: The tone shifts from _____ to _____ at “_____.”

Sound Hunt

Hunt the “Harvest Watch” stanza for repeated sounds and explain their effect.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Highlight every alliteration, assonance, and rhyme you hear.
- 2 Read the stanza aloud twice — once flat, once with feeling.
- 3 Explain what the repeated sounds do to the stanza's feeling.

Prove it: The repeated _____ sound in “_____” makes the stanza feel _____.

Say It Again

Analyze why an author repeats a line instead of writing it once.

YOUR STEPS

- 1 Find the repeated line in the stanza and the repeated word in Part 2.
- 2 Explain what repetition adds each time.
- 3 Rewrite one without the repetition. What is lost?

Prove it: Repeating _____ makes the reader feel _____, which a single mention would not.

DISCUSSION

Sentence starters for sharing out

To name a meaning

"In this text, _____ means _____, because the author says ..."

To claim a tone

"The author's tone is _____. I know because ..."

To build on a peer

"I'd add to _____'s point — another word that shows it is ..."

To argue connotation

"_____ carries a _____ feeling that _____ doesn't have."

To analyze sound

"The repeated _____ makes this section feel _____."

To respectfully disagree

"I read that differently. The word _____ suggests ..."

Running the lesson — pacing & facilitation

Open

10 min

Slides 3–9: definitions with quick turn-and-talks.

Don't lecture all five — check for understanding after each.

Model

15 min

Slides 10–17: work the examples, then read the passage twice.

Think aloud in first person so the reasoning is audible.

Practice

30 min

Task cards 1–8 in partners, 6–8 minutes each.

Circulate; ask “where's your evidence?” at every stop.

Close

10 min

Share-out with the sentence starters, then the exit ticket.

Collect exit tickets as your formative data.

Support, challenge & what to look for

If students struggle

Give the tone word bank as a closed list of four.

Pre-highlight the clue sentences in the passage.

Let them answer orally before writing.

Pair cards 1 and 2 only.

To push further

Rewrite Part 1 in the opposite tone, same events.

Compare the passage's tone to a song lyric.

Write an original four-line stanza using two sound devices.

Argue which single word carries the most weight.

Watch for these errors

Naming a device without explaining its effect.

Summarizing the plot instead of analyzing words.

Confusing tone (writer) with mood (reader).

Quoting with no explanation attached.

EXIT TICKET

Three lines before you go

1 One word from the passage and what it means — in your own words, with the clue you used.

2 The tone of “The Long Way Home,” named in one precise word, plus one quote that proves it.

3 One example of repeated sound and what it does to the reader.

RL.7.4 — Determine meaning · Analyze word impact · Explain the effect of sound